Harjas Bansoota

Professor Tiffany Potter

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Ableism in *The Island of Doctor Moreau*

In *The Island of Doctor Moreau,* H.G. Wells deviates from Victorian norms by using the animalistic characterization of the Beast People alongside the fear of regression generated by the uncanny Beasts to create a source of horror. This is used in a way that corresponds with the ableism that ran rampant during the Victorian era, indicating that people with a disability during the 19th century were animals and lesser humans - an inhumane and outdated take int the 21st century. The pejorative view of disabled people has strong roots in the belief of Social Darwinism and behaviour that was perceived as madness. Social Darwinists use Charles Darwin's theory of evolution - a theory stating all organisms adapt and change through the natural selection of the beneficial traits of their ancestors - to substantiate their belief that those with power in society are innately better and more evolved human beings than those who are not. This belief justified the mistreatment and abuse of minorities in Social Darwinist's eyes as they believed minorities were more primitive and animalistic versions of humans that need to be weeded out of society. Madness, in the Victorian era, was believed as behaviour that was socially deviant. This included people with mental illnesses and with physical disabilities. Mentally and physically disabled people were placed into mental asylums in which the patients were commonly abused and exposed to inhumane conditions due to a lack of understanding of the causes behind their conditions. The intent of this essay is to interrogate the relationship between the Beast People and the 19th century's perception of people with mental and physical illnesses.

Comprehending this relationship will then allow for the understanding of why the deviation from normality was a significant source of horror in *The Island of Doctor Moreau.*

The Beast People's characterization is used to establish the connection between the Beasts and people with a disability. Understanding the connection will allow for the examination of what makes this connection invoke horror in the reader. The Beast People's behaviour can be examined through the Law which can help us understand why the Beast People are viewed as sub-human. The Law is a set of rules the Beast People follow as an emulation of religion. The Law consists of the Beast's chanting out the behaviour they are prohibited from, such as,

> Not to go on all-fours; that is the Law. Are we not Men?
>
> Not to suck up Drink; that is the Law. Are we not Men?
>
> Not to eat Fish or Flesh; that is the Law. Are we not Men?
>
> Not to claw the Bark of Trees; that is the Law. Are we not Men?
>
> Not to chase other Men; that is the Law. Are we not Men? (Wells and Harris 114)

This is followed up with punishments in which the Beasts refer to Moreau as a God, which is supported by the capitalization of the letter "h" in the text when they sing their chant, "His is the Hand that makes. His is the Hand that wounds. His is the Hand that heals." (Wells and Harris 114). This Law or religion in which Moreau is held up to be a God is seen by Prendick as a sub-human and crude attempt at religion. Prendick states the prohibitions the Law states are the "maddest … and most indecent things one could imagine … [and] deep within [him] laughter and disgust struggled" (Wells and Harris 114). The battle of laughter and disgust represents the absurdness of these rules for one who is human, as it is almost incomprehensible to imagine a human performing these prohibited acts. The absurdity in the prohibitions however creates

disgust at the thought of carrying out such heinous acts. The Law the Beasts have created is representative of the eternal struggle they feel as they repress the "true animalism" (Wells and Harris 101) within them, in an attempt to become human. The fact that the struggle even exists within the Beasts asserts to Prendick and the reader that the Beasts are forever doomed to be an intermediate form of humans - more than animals yet never human. They are simply the next step forward in evolution for animals, but an evolutionary step down from humans.

By asserting that the Beasts are the middle ground in between humankind and animals, the language used to describe their appearance can be examined to identify the connection it has with how people with disability were viewed in the 19th century. Edward Prendick's - the narrator of the book and stand in for the typical Victorian man - initial description of the Beast M'Ling's physical characteristics, who he believed was human at the time, was describing him as a "black-faced man" (Wells and Harris 78) with a "crooked back [and] a hairy neck" (Wells and Harris 78) alongside a face that stuck out "forming something dimly suggestive of a muzzle … [with] big white teeth" (Wells and Harris 78). After noting these features - which were typically associated with physical or mental disability in the 19th century - Prendick instantly changed his perspective on M'Ling, feeling astonishment at the "grotesque ugliness of this black-faced creature" (Wells and Harris 79). Prendick's subtle change in calling M'Ling a black-faced creature instead of a man show how Prendick, the stand-in for the typical reader of the time, believes the qualities above belong to creatures and animals, rather than to men. By referring to one with these animal-like qualities as a creature it becomes clear that Prendick, and in turn society during the 19th century, believed that those with these characteristics cannot be classified as men or humans. This association is corroborated by Charles Darwin in *The*

Expression of the Emotions in Man as Darwin describes Dr. Henry Maudsley's common view of mental illness at the time wherein he states “animal-like traits [are seen] in idiots … which man has … outgrown” (244). The belief of animal traits being a sign of disability is part of a “long tradition … of treating disabled humans both metaphorically and literally as animals” (Dwyer 12), especially in the Victorian era. Prendick later provides concrete evidence that this is true when he meets the rest of the Beast People who he now calls “the most horrible cripples and maniacs” (Wells and Harris 115). This explicit comparison of sub-human Beasts with disabled people provides concrete evidence that those with a disability are also seen as lesser, devolved humans. By making it clear that those with a disability were seen as the equivalent of the devolved Beasts, the horror this created can be delved into.

H.G. Wells utilizes the uncanniness of the Beasts to reawaken the horror that came from the thought of regression in the 19th century reader. To analyze the horror inspired by the Beasts, we must first understand what the word uncanny means, specifically its meaning in gothic literature - a genre *The Island of Doctor Moreau* belongs to. Sigmund Freud distinguished the meaning of uncanny from mysterious or fearful by describing uncanny as, “the class of the terrifying which leads back to something long known to us, once very familiar” (Weaver-Hightower and Piwarski 360). Freud continues to elaborate how an uncanny feeling is invoked when a situation is reminiscent “of some earlier phase or struggle, which individuals would like to believe they or their society has progressed through but which they fear has not been completely surmounted… [The uncanny] marks the resurfacing of repressed fears” (Weaver-Hightower and Piwarski 362). This exact feeling is seen within *The Island of Doctor Moreau* when Prendick realizes what it was about the Beasts that unsettled him:

> I perceived clearly for the first time what it was that had offended me, what had given me the two inconsistent and conflicting impressions of utter strangeness and yet of the strangest familiarity. The three creatures engaged in this mysterious rite were human in shape, and yet human beings with the strangest air about them of some familiar animal. Each of these creatures, despite its human form, its rag of clothing, and the rough humanity of its bodily form, had woven into it--into its movements, into the expression of its countenance, into its whole presence - some now irresistible suggestion of a hog, a swinish taint, the unmistakable mark of the beast. (Wells and Harris 100)

As Prendick realizes that these Beasts have a similarity to humans, the reader simultaneously comes to this realization as the reader learns directly through Prendick's narration. The description of the Beast's human shape combined with an unmistakable beastly aura suggests that humans may have similar traits to the Beasts within them. This reawakens a dormant fear within the 19th century reader as realizing that a "bestial-looking monster" (Wells and Harris 100) could be reminiscent of humans raises the question of what is stopping humans from regressing into the intermediate form of evolution the Beasts represent.

The horror this question inspired in the Victorian era played on the fact that "the fear of descending to a lower type or order … was omnipresent in colonial societies" (Weaver-Hightower and Piwarski 360). The fear of regression and degeneration in the Victorian era had roots in Social Darwinism. Social Darwinist's popularity resulted in the rise of ableism as Social Darwinists believed disabilities to be a lack of evolution. This directly created fear in the thought of regressing or devolving into an animalistic state as being anything other than the typical European of the time was harshly discriminated against. This is exemplified in Prendick's initial

reaction in which he believes that Moreau was vivisecting humans and turning them into Beasts. Prendick's panic-stricken run across the island highlights the horror felt by the thought of being "infected with some bestial taint" (Wells and Harris 120) as Prendick was ready to commit suicide before possibly being forced to regress to a bestial form. This fear is used to create horror in *The Island of Doctor Moreau* as the Beast People's uncanny resemblance to humans calls upon this fear. The Beast People reawaken the fear of regression in the 19th century reader as the Beasts force the reader to rethink if their animalistic tendencies have truly been phased out by evolution. The Social Darwinist belief that people with disabilities were devolved humans is now used to reaffirm this fear as it provides those in the 19th century with a real, tangible example of this fear, rather than simply a fictional concept.

H.G. Wells characterizes the animalistic Beast People in a way that links it to the discriminatory view of those with perceived "madness". Wells used this to capitalize on the fear of regression that was prevalent due to ableism that was fueled by Social Darwinism in the Victorian era. This created an uncanny feeling throughout the whole of *The Island of Doctor Moreau* creating true gothic horror through its deviation from the norms present in Victorian society. While this essay only focused on *The Island of Doctor Moreau*, the implications of ableism creating a fear of regression can be examined deeper in other texts and expanded on to determine the role ableism played within society in the past, as well as how it has changed how we view those with disabilities today. This could be examined in other pieces of historical literature such as William Shakespeare's *The Tempest*, in which Caliban is treated as a lesser being due to his physical deformities, or in Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein*, in which the titular monster can be interpreted as the Victorian view on physical and mental disabilities alongside

the use of the word “Frankenstein” as an allusion being used in today’s day and age. Examining these can raise the question of whether 21st century society has truly moved on from the widespread ableism of the past.

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Harjas Bansoota

Professor Tiffany Potter

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Uncanny Horror in *The Island of Doctor Moreau*

In *The Island of Doctor Moreau,* H.G. Wells uses deviation from socially acceptable standards on the island and the uncanny characterization of the Beast People as a source of horror. Using the abnormal as a source of horror is significant as it corresponds with the contemptuous view of people who do not fit the mold of what was seen as a typical and ~~civilized~~ human being - people of colour and people with a disability - during the 19th century. The pejorative view of ~~people of colour and~~ disabled people has strong roots in the belief of social Darwinism and behaviour that was perceived as madness. Social Darwinists use Charles Darwin's theory of evolution - a theory stating all organisms adapt and change through the natural selection of the beneficial traits of their ancestors - to substantiate their belief that those with power in society are innately better and more evolved human beings than those who are not. This belief justified the mistreatment and abuse of minorities in social Darwinist's eyes as they believed minorities were more primitive and animalistic versions of humans that need to be weeded out of society. Madness, in the 19th century, was believed as behaviour that was socially deviant. This included mental illness and physical disabilities. The mentally ill and physically disabled were placed into mental asylums in which the patients were commonly abused and exposed to inhumane conditions due to a lack of understanding of the causes behind their conditions. [redacted] This essay will interrogate the relationship between the Beast People and the 19th century's perception of the

mentally ill and disabled. Comprehending this relationship will then allow for the understanding of why the deviation from normality was a significant source of horror in *The Island of Doctor Moreau.*

The description given to the reader about the Beast Folk's physical attributes and behaviour in *The Island of Doctor Moreau* is not only animalistic, but outstandingly similar to the descriptions given to people with disability and people of colour. Edward Prendrick's - the narrator of the book and stand in for the typical 19th century man - initial description of the beast M'Ling's physical characteristics, who he believed was human at the time, was describing him as a "black-faced man" (Wells and Harris 78) with a "crooked back [and] a hairy neck" (Wells and Harris 78) alongside a face that stuck out "forming something dimly suggestive of a muzzle … [with] big white teeth" (Wells and Harris 78). Prendrick then ~~went on to feel astonishment at the~~ "grotesque ugliness of this black-faced creature" (Wells and Harris 79). These features, such as the crooked back, tend to be prevalent in those with a physical or mental disability, or as it was said in the 19th century, those who are mad. Prendrick's subtle change in downgrading M'Ling from a black-faced man to a black-faced creature due to these features shows the reader how Prendrick, the stand-in for the typical reader of the time, believes the qualities above belong to creatures and animals, rather than to men. By referring to one with these animal-like qualities as a creature it is clear that Prendrick, and in turn the society during the 19th century, believed that those with these characteristics cannot be classified as men or humans. This association is corroborated in Charle's Darwin's *The Expression of the Emotions in Man* as Darwin describes Dr. Henry Maudsley's common view of mental illness wherein he states "animal-like traits [are seen] in idiots" (244) and that "the brain of an idiot … will manifest its most primitive functions,

and no higher functions" (245-246). This is further cemented when Prendrick meets the rest of the Beast People who he explicitly now calls "the most horrible cripples and maniacs" (Wells and Harris 115) providing concrete evidence that those with a disability are seen as beasts or animals. This is upheld by Jane Dwyer who states that there is a "long tradition … of treating disabled humans both metaphorically and literally as animals" (12) during the 19th century. The characterization of the Beast People makes evident that the Beast People are held in the same regard as those who were perceived as "mad" in the 19th century.

The examination of the Beast People's Law can be used to understand why the Beast's and those with perceived madness are categorized as more than animals, but still sub-human. The Beast People's Law is a set of rules that they follow as an emulation of religion. The Law consists of the Beast's chanting out the behaviour they are prohibited from, such as,

> Not to go on all-fours; that is the Law. Are we not Men?
>
> Not to suck up Drink; that is the Law. Are we not Men?
>
> Not to eat Fish or Flesh; that is the Law. Are we not Men?
>
> Not to claw the Bark of Trees; that is the Law. Are we not Men?
>
> Not to chase other Men; that is the Law. Are we not Men? (Wells and Harris 114)

This is followed up with punishments in which the beasts refer to Moreau as ~~a god~~, which is supported by the capitalization of the letter "h" in the text when they sing their chant,

> His is the House of Pain.
>
> His is the Hand that makes.
>
> His is the Hand that wounds.
>
> His is the Hand that heals. (Wells and Harris 114)

This Law or religion in which Moreau is held up to be a god and creator, but also distribute pain is seen by Prendrick as a sub-human and lower life-form attempt at religion. Prendrick states the prohibitions are the "maddest … and most indecent things one could imagine … [and] deep within me laughter and disgust struggled" (Wells and Harris 114). The battle of laughter and disgust represents the outlandishness of these rules, as Prendrick, being human, cannot comprehend that these rules need to exist for one who is human. This Law the Beasts have created is representative of the eternal struggle they feel as they repress "true animalism" (Wells and Harris 101) within them, in an attempt to be human. This struggle, however, shows how the Beasts are forever doomed to be seen as more, than an animal, but always sub-human as this battle of animal and man does not exists for human. This indicates that the sub-human state the Beast People are in is an evolutionary step down from humanity, but the next step in evolution for animals.

By having it clear that the creations of Moreau are also how 19th century views people with disabilities, the horror they inspired in the typical 19th century individual can be examined. To analyze the horror inspired, we must first understand what the word uncanny means, ~~specifically its meaning~~ in gothic literature - which *The Island of Doctor Moreau* belongs to. Sigmund Freud, who wrote an essay on this uncanniness, distinguished uncanny from mysterious or fearful by describing uncanny as "the class of the terrifying which leads back to something long known to us, once very familiar" (Weaver-Hightower and Piwarski 360). This understanding of the uncanny is seen within *The Island of Doctor Moreau* repeatedly as the Beasts continually remind Prendrick - and the reader - of the similarities they have with

humanity, while also being strikingly different. The feeling of uncanniness is stated explicitly by Prendrick when he realizes what it was about the Beast's that unsettled him. ~~Prendrick states,~~

> I perceived clearly for the first time what it was that had offended me, what had given me the two inconsistent and conflicting impressions of utter strangeness and yet of the strangest familiarity. The three creatures engaged in this mysterious rite were human in shape, and yet human beings with the strangest air about them of some familiar animal. Each of these creatures, despite its human form, its rag of clothing, and the rough humanity of its bodily form, had woven into it--into its movements, into the expression of its countenance, into its whole presence - some now irresistible suggestion of a hog, a swinish taint, the unmistakable mark of the beast. (Wells and Harris 100)

As Prendrick realizes that these Beast's have a similarity to humans, the reader simultaneously comes to this realization as the reader learns directly through Prendricks narration. The description of the Beast's human shape combined with an unmistakable beastly aura suggests to Prendrick and the reader that humans may have similar traits to the Beast's within them. This understanding that a "bestial-looking monster" (Wells and Harris 100) could be reminiscent of humans invokes an uncanny feeling as it raises the fearful question to the 19th century reader of ~~what truly separates the Beasts from humankind and~~ what is stopping humans from regressing into the intermediate form of evolution represented by the Beast's and, through the unfortunate association of the era, the disabled.

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The horror this question inspired in the 19th century played on the fact that "the fear of descending to a lower type or order … was omnipresent in colonial societies" (Weaver-Hightower and Piwarski 360). This is exemplified in Prendrick's initial reaction in

which he believes that Moreau was vivisecting humans and turning them into Beasts. Prendrick panic-stricken run across the island highlights the horror felt by the thought of being "infected with some bestial taint" (Wells and Harris 120) during the 19th century as Prendrick was ready to commit suicide before possibly regressing to a bestial form. The fear of regression and degeneration in the 19th century had roots in social Darwinism. Social Darwinist's popularity resulted in the mistreatment of minorities across many categories; including the disabled, believing their disabilities to be a lack of evolution. This mistreatment, although popular, directly created fear in the thought of regressing or devolving into an animalistic state. This fear is used to create horror in *The Island of Doctor Moreau* as the Beast People's uncanny resemblance to humans causes a conflict within the reader as they see their inner animalistic tendencies personified in an exaggerated manner by the Beasts. The belief that the disabled were a primitive or devolved humans is also pulled in to reaffirm this fear. It provides a real world analogy for those in the 19th century, making the horror in the thought of regressing real and tangible, rather than words on a page.

H.G. Wells uses Beast People as a deviation from 19th century societal norms to invoke horror by creating an uncanny feeling throughout *The Island of Doctor Moreau.* Wells establishes the Beast People as sub-human creatures, fighting with their inner animalism in a feeble attempt to become human. This idea is built upon as the characterization of the Beast People is made to be a clear representation of how 19th century society perceived those with a disability. With it made clear that Beast People and in turn disabled people are seen as sub-human, examining the feeling of uncanniness invoked by their description lead to the discovery of the fear of regression that accompanies this feeling. This fear was found to be

fueled by Social Darwinism in the 19th century which created a disparaging view of the "mad".

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